r/aiwars

Can someone give me a chart about water usage for AI?

Posted by u/RiasGremory3 • • 0 points • 9 comments

And tell me where you got your sources

Comments

u/Asleep_Stage_451 • 1 points • 2025-11-19 15:31 UTC

Random one at top of a Google search https://bryantresearch.co.uk/insight-items/comparing-water-footprint-ai/

> **u/Asleep_Stage_451** • 1 points • 2025-11-19 15:32 UTC
>
> This too https://johnaugust.com/2025/more-on-ai-environmental-costs

u/laurenblackfox • 2 points • 2025-11-19 12:06 UTC

Here's how Google is being responsible with their water usage: https://datacenters.google/water/

It's fascinating stuff. Most of the pro-ai side will cite 'closed loop' systems and handwave the issue away. While true, it's not the full story.

All the datacenters I've ever worked in were air cooled in climate controlled spaces. Which basically run like your home PC, in an air conditioned room, but scaled up.

Water cooled systems are typically closed-loop. Which means that there's a stock reservoir of water at the datacenter, which is fed into the cooling system. The cold water is heated up by the servers, pumped out to a radiator or refrigeration system, then pumped back in. There's often some loss due to leakages, and such, but these amounts are comparatively small and will need topping up over time. Systems will need flushing occasionally, where the water is renewed, but this isn't an everyday occurrence.

There are some datacenters that use water from community sources. Typically these work on overflow and/or waste water after it's been used by the local source. The datacenter will perform their own on-site water cleaning process before using it in their water cooling system. The used water is then dumped back into the community waste water system. I am unaware of any datacenter using this kind of system using fresh source water.

I hope this helps.

u/Murky-Orange-8958 • 1 points • 2025-11-19 10:15 UTC https://preview.redd.it/jrlw7zhkv62g1.png?width=1979&format=png&auto=webp&s=67faa549cd7390c6d59c22a144ec9ac844378ce1

u/hari_shevek • 1 points • 2025-11-23 01:37 UTC

That's not a source. It doesn't say where the numbers are from, just 4 organization logos without a link to the actual articles the numbers came from.

u/Murky-Orange-8958 • 1 points • 2025-11-24 09:50 UTC

I know I just generated it. But it does fulfill OP's request, technically.

u/hari_shevek • 1 points • 2025-11-24 09:52 UTC

So you lied

u/Whilpin • 1 points • 2025-11-19 07:58 UTC

well, the question itself is nuanced. It takes a TON of water just to make computer chips in the first place. It also hurts the environment to power huge datacenters (but to be fair, we've known for a long time this was going to get much worse for over a decade and we did nothing - in fact I think the US got *worse*), then theres the water for the cooling stacks for the datacenters themselves (apparently they're evaporative cooled, they water cool the closed loop that contacts the actual hardware). Like how far down the rabbit hole are you asking for?

u/PikachuTrainz • 1 points • 2025-11-19 08:51 UTC

Maybe they're talking about the water used when some ai-genned thing is prompted and generated

u/Whilpin • 1 points • 2025-11-19 09:18 UTC

oh I had one user accuse me of using 1KW per hour making a single image. lol I was like "dude I have my stats right here". Laid out the math, totalled about 0.042 KW per hour. Enough to heat a liter of water 36 degrees C (piss-warm, basically) over that hour. Datacenters have *far* faster and *far* more efficient very specialized hardware than my consumer GPU - they could probably do the same thing in half the time for half the power. So the fact that they're using *so much* power suggests that a LOT of people are using it. (but they're also using wwwwaaaayyyyy bigger models than I do - in fact they all use their own proprietary model, so you cant just calculate one and judge them all by it). But I suspect even then it's a fraction of the power I use per image.

u/Icy_Mycologist_172 • 1 points • 2025-11-19 07:58 UTC

Have you tried this cool website? www.google.com

u/Competitive-Help9782 • 1 points • 2025-11-19 13:41 UTC

`![gif](giphy|de9SDw6PGRsubN1o3X)`